Wanda Hickey's Night of Golden Memories

By Jean Shepherd

REPORTER: **(Pg 299 – 300)** Puberty rites in the more primitive tribal societies are almost invariably painful and traumatic experiences . . . A classic example is the Ugga Buggah tribe of lower Micronesia. When an Ugga Buggah reaches puberty, the rites are rigorous for both sexes. Difficult dances are performed and the candidate for adulthood must eat a sickening ritual meal during the postdance banquet. You will also notice that his costume is as uncomfortable as it is decorative . . . Here we see the ritual dance in progress. *(An obviously uncomfortably dressed young man dances a crazy ritual dance to heavy drum beats)* Of course, we in more sophisticated societies no longer observe these rites . . .

INTRODUCTION

Or do they? Wanda Hickey's Night of Golden Memories by Jean Shepherd

SCHWARTZ: **(Pg 301-302)** You going to the prom? I read on the bulletin board where it said you wear a summer formal to the prom.

ME: That's where you wear one of those white coats. Ya gotta rent 'em. *(To audience)* **(Pg 305-312)** The next day, after school, Schwartz and I went downtown to Al's Swank Formalwear. Rented by the day or hour, free fittings! I could feel excitement rising deep inside me.

AL: OK, boys. Ya wanna make it big at the prom, am I right? Ya come to the right place. *(Yelling to the back room)* HEY, MORTY! HERE'S [ONE] MORE FOR THAT BASH AT CHERRYWOOD. I'D SAY ONE FAWTY REGULAH."

MORTY: THE FAWTY AIN'T BEEN CLEANED YET!

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AL: BRING IT OUT, AWREADY! This suit just come in from anotha job. Don't worry about how it looks. We'll clean it up an' take it in so's it'll fit good.

ME: Al held up the suit invitingly. *(slips his arms into the jacket)*

AL: Perfect. Couldn't be bettuh. Take it in a little here . . . An' doan worry 'bout the stain; we'll get it out. Here, try on these pants.

ME: *(Putting on the pants)* They were rumpled and smelled strongly of some spilled beverage, but they were truly magnificent. The waist came to just a shade below my armpits. *(sashaying around)*

AL: Perfect. Just right. Put a little tuck in the waist, so. *(Grabbing several yards of the seat)* And a little in here. You're [a] high-class customers. Now, I suppose ya wanna go first class right? . . . . Right?

ME: *(To audience)* With an air of mystery, he bent over, slid open a drawer and placed atop the counter an object that unfocused my eyes with its sheer brilliance.

AL: A genuwine Hollywood paisley cummabund. It's only a buck extra . . . [And] how do you expect to trip the light fantastic without a pair of black patent-leatha dancin' pumps?

ME: Dancin' what?

AL: *(Irritably)* Shoes, shoes. And we throw in the socks for nuttin'. How 'bout it?

ME: *(To audience)* Step by step, in the ancient tradition, the tribal ritual was being acted out. The prom was now two weeks off . . . **(Pg 315)** Everything was set to go, except for one thing – no girl.

SCHWARTZ: How ya doin' with Daphne Bigelow?

ME: Oh, that. I haven't had time to ask her. *(To audience)* **(pg 312)** [She] drifted by on gossamer wings, her brilliant smile lighting up the corners of homeroom. **(Pg 314)** [Then there was only] one week to go. I knew I could never ask Daphne Bigelow to be my date . . .

MOM: **(Pg 303)** Why not take that nice Wanda Hickey?

ME: Ah, come on, Ma. This is the prom. This is important. You don't take Wanda Hickey to the prom. *(To audience)* Wanda Hickey was the only girl who I knew for an absolute fact liked me. She laughed at my jokes and once when we were 12, actually sent me a valentine. **(pg 315-319)** A feeling of helpless rage settled over me as I [went to water] the lawn.

WANDA: What are you doing?

ME: *(Somewhat exasperated)* Oh, hi, Wanda. I'm sprinkling the lawn.

WANDA: I'm sure glad school's almost over. I never thought I'd be a senior.

ME: Yeah. *(To audience)* Then it happened. I realized there was no sense fighting it. Some guys are born to dance forever with the Daphne Bigelows. Others – well, they do the best they can. *(To Wanda)* Would you . . . well . . . I mean uh . . . how about . . . going to the prom with me? *(To audience)* The die was cast. There was no turning back . . . **(Pg 326)** [Prom] day dawned bright and sunny, as perfect as a day can be. **(Pg 328-333)** I took two showers. I knew what happened to people who didn't – disastrous B.O. It would not happen to me. *(sniffs armpits)* Tonight I would be a truly magnificent specimen of lusty manhood. Laid out on my bed was my beautiful summer formal. *(In words and pantomime)* Carefully, I undid the pins that festooned my pleated Monte Carlo shirt. I struggled to get [the studs] in place between the concrete slits. It was impossible! Never in my life had I experienced a collar remotely like the one that now clamped its iron grasp around my windpipe. It dug mercilessly into my throat – a mere sample of what was to come. Tie, shoes, cummerbund and snowy coat. And there I stood – Adonis! *(Admiring himself in the mirror)* **(Pg 334-335)** When I pulled up before Wanda's house, she was out on the porch. With stately tread, I moved up the walk; my pants were so tight that if I'd taken one false step, God knows what would have happened. *(Sees Wanda*

and his mouth drops open) This was NOT the old Wanda. For one thing, she didn't have her glasses on, and her eyes were unnaturally large and liquid. Milky skin and golden hair radiating in the glow of the porch light. In accordance with the tribal custom, we drove off through the soft night. [And] from all over town, other cars, polished and waxed, carried the rest of the junior class to their great trial by fire.

REPORTER: **(pg 300)** Here we see the ritual dance in progress. *(An obviously uncomfortably dressed young man dances a crazy ritual dance which shifts to the standard box step as the Ugga Buggah tribesman morphs into our narrator)* **(Pg 336-341)** 1-2-3 Pause . . . Back and forth, up and down. 1-2-3 Pause . . . By now my dashing concrete collar had removed a wide strip of skin encircling my neck. Wanda was exhaling directly into my face with a heady essence of cough drops and sauerkraut. [She] started to sweat through her taffeta. I felt it running down her back. My own back was already wet and the sweat, which had now saturated my jockey shorts was pouring down my legs. I pulled [her] closer and we swung back into action. .1-2-3 Pause . . . . [Then] all of a sudden, it was over. The band played Good Night, Sweetheart and we were out . . . . SEE YOU AT THE ROOSTER! – The savage tribal rite was nearing its final and most vicious phase.

REPORTER: **(Pg 300)** The candidate for adulthood must eat a sickening ritual meal during the postdance banquet.

ME: **(pg 342-347)** A beady-eyed waiter, hair glistening with Vaseline Hair Oil, sidled over and hovered like a vulture. Quickly distributing the famous Red Rooster Deluxe Menu, he smirked and waited for us to impress our dates.

WAITER: Can I bring you anything to drink?

ME: My first impulse was to order my favorite drink, a bottled chocolate concoction called Kayo, the Wonder Drink; but remembering that better

things were expected of me on prom night, I said, in my deepest voice, Uh . . . make mine . . . burbon.

WAITER: How will you have it, sir?

ME: Well, in a glass, I guess and make it a triple. *(To audience)* I had some vague idea that this was a brand or something. I also ordered – for reasons that even today I am unable to explain – lamb chops, yellow turnips, mashed potatoes and gravy, and a side dish of Italian Cole slaw. *(Acknowledges the waiter returning with the drink)* Swiftly, I brought the bourbon to my lips, intending to down it in a single devil-may-care [shot]. Down it went – a screaming 90-proof rocket searing savagely down my gullet. *(Eyes watering, unable to gasp for breath, but trying desperately to appear manly)*

WANDA: Isn't this romantic? Isn't this the most wonderful night in all our lives?

ME: Urk . . . Urk . . . yeah! In all the excitement of preparation for the prom, I realized that I hadn't eaten a single thing all day. Maybe [food] would help! *(Lowers head and shovels food in quickly)* I tried the potatoes and gravy. I wolfed down the Cole slaw. My stomach . . . .

(He's obviously going to get sick, struggles down the hallway to the bathroom, holding onto the wall – makes it to the rest room and throws up violently into the toilet – after he recovers, he wipes his mouth with the back of his hand)

(To audience) **(Pg 348-349)** It was the absolute high point of the junior prom.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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